government by October, and all the splits make for a combustible cocktail. Already, they have created a curious problem of plenty for the saffron party ahead of the Lok Sabha poll. The BJP leader admits his party would have to "pick and choose" when it comes to inducting Congressmen, as the ruling alliance was already "saturated". Such inductions could upset those leaders of the Mahayuti (grand alliance) constituents who have been nursing political ambitions of their own. And then there is the multiplicity of ideologies at play too. With Ajit Pawar backing the demand for reservation for minorities, as the surprise extension of the idea of a caste census, the BJP could very well find itself in a fix in days to come.

But all this is nothing compared to the Congress's plight. Already, in a sign of impending trouble, around 10 of 44 Congress MLAs stayed away from a party conclave at Lonavala on February 16-17. An Independent MLA who is close to the BJP says Chavan's move could not have been a leap in the dark. "He wouldn't have joined the BJP unless he had promised the BJP leadership that he would bring something substantial to the table," he said. "He may at least get the MLAs from Nanded and Marathwada on his side."

Chavan began his electoral career as a Congress MP from Nanded (1987-89), inheriting the political mantle of his father—the late S.B. Chavan, who was a two-time Maharashtra CM, and later the Union home minister. Today, he holds sway over parts of Marathwada, notably Nanded and adjoining Hingoli, especially over the local power centres such as municipal bodies, sugar mills and cooperatives. In 2014, Chavan had handed a face-saver to the Congress by winning the Nanded Lok Sabha seat and working for the victory of Rahul Gandhi's confidant Rajiv Satav from Hingoli. The two were the only Congress victors from Maharashtra. But, in 2019, he faced a shock defeat, before being elected to the state assembly from Bhokar and joining the Uddhav-led MVA government.

SPLIT WIDE OPEN

- **For the Maharashtra Congress, the exit of Ashok Chavan is the third jolt within a month, after former Union minister Milind Deora and ex-state minister Baba Siddiqui's desertion**
- **The BJP is projecting it as a third vertical split in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) since 2022, after Eknath Shinde and Ajit Pawar's coup within the Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), respectively**
- **In a sign of impending trouble, around 10 of the 44 Congress MLAs stayed away from a party conclave at Lonavala on February 16-17**

THE BJP TOO FACES A PROBLEM OF PLENTY IN ACCOMMODATING MORE POTENTIAL CONGRESS REBELS IN A 'SATURATED' RULING ALLIANCE

Incidentally, Chavan's exit from the Congress came just days after the Union government released a white paper that detailed various "governance, economic and fiscal crises" and corruption scandals during the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) regime, the Adarsh housing society scam among them. The Adarsh case—involving alleged irregularities in the allotment of flats in a housing project in upscale South Mumbai—had cost Chavan his CM's post in 2010.

So, was his exit prompted by a possible Enforcement Directorate (ED) action? Chavan denies any such speculation. Talking to INDIA TODAY, the former CM said his decision was a result of "the lack of action within the party" and the style of working of the state leadership—an apparent attack on Maharashtra Congress chief Nana Patole. "This was leading to a gnawing sense of frustration," he said, "as the elections were coming close. In the last six to eight months, the party had not prepared [for the polls], while others had gone down to the village level in their campaigning. Here, there were only discussions."

Even as a senior Congress leader points to the likely "psychological impact" of Chavan's "sudden" move on the party cadre, Congress legislature party leader Balasaheb Thorat refutes the possibility of any split. Another Congress leader, who also wished to remain anonymous, waxes confident that Congress MLAs would not defect en masse to the BJP, claiming that Chavan's revolt differed from that of Shinde's and Ajit Pawar's, which had been "brewing for a while". "Chavan or any defector will not be able to muster the support of two-thirds of Congress MLAs, and will have to resign from their seats," says the leader. "This will affect their bargaining power, and they may be denied a renomination in favour of contenders from the three other parties in the Mahayuti."

Even Chavan was reportedly eager to become a deputy CM with a plum portfolio, but the idea is said to have met with opposition from the BJP ranks. Chavan maintains that he has not "invited" any Congress MLA to follow him into the BJP, even though, he says, they too are "worried about the future". According to Hemant Desai, a journalist and political analyst, "all does not seem well within the Congress" after Chavan's exit. How this development plays out for the party will become clear soon enough, as the poll frenzy reaches a fever pitch. ■